

ADVANCING FIRST CLASS PRE-K IN ALABAMA

Seats, Not Unit Cost: What Twenty-Four Years of Pre-K Growth Bought

State investment, enrollment, and per-child spending in Alabama, 2002–2025

JoonHo Lee and Alison Hooper ■ August 2026

In 2002, Alabama’s state pre-K served 756 four-year-olds on a state investment of \$5.7 million; in 2024–25, First Class Pre-K served 24,238 children on \$185.4 million. In this brief we examine what those twenty-four years of growth bought, drawing on the inflation-adjusted series in the NIEER *State of Preschool* yearbooks. We find that growth in state investment is associated with nearly proportional growth in the number of children served: investment rose 32.3-fold and enrollment rose 32.1-fold, two multiples that land within a rounding step of each other, while spending per enrolled child ended close to where it started, at \$7,585 in 2002 and \$7,651 now.

Three patterns define the record:

- **Investment and enrollment grew in lockstep.** A 32-fold rise in real state dollars accompanied a 32-fold rise in children served (figure 1), a pattern consistent with growth that came from adding classrooms rather than from raising the price of each seat.
- **Per-child spending dipped, then recovered, and quality held.** During the fastest expansion years, per-child state spending fell as much as 24 percent below its 2002 level, bottoming at \$5,763 in 2016, before climbing back (figure 2). Even at that low point, Alabama met all 10 NIEER quality benchmarks.

- **Alabama’s national position improved.** The state’s four-year-old enrollment share climbed from 36th of 39 operating jurisdictions in 2002 to 15th by 2022, and it stood 18th of 46 in 2024–25 (figure 3).

We treat these as descriptive accounting patterns in state-reported, inflation-adjusted dollars: they do not measure spending adequacy or program effects, and we return to their limits at the end of the brief.

The Growth Model and the Next Phase of Expansion

Every expansion debate contains an implicit question: does growing a program mean buying more seats, costlier seats, or both? For its first twenty-four years Alabama’s history offers an unusually clean answer, because the state scaled at an essentially constant real unit cost, and that record is the natural baseline for what comes next. Yet the next phase may not come at the same price, since the remaining unserved children are disproportionately in communities where sites are harder to open and to staff, and the compensation pressures documented elsewhere in this series bear on what a seat is likely to cost going forward.

This brief is the fifth in the *Advancing First Class Pre-K in Alabama* series; it pairs with our national comparison in brief 4 (Lee and Hooper 2026c) and sets up the funding-structure and workforce briefs that follow.

BOX 1

Data and Methods

Data. We assembled the NIEER *State of Preschool* yearbooks, 2002–2025 editions, into a 51-jurisdiction panel; this brief uses the Alabama series together with cross-state enrollment ranks. Dollar amounts are the yearbook’s inflation-adjusted 2025 dollars, so the growth figures we report are real rather than nominal.

Measures. “State investment” is total state pre-K spending, and “per-child” divides that total by enrollment, so it moves when either one moves; we therefore report the two together throughout. Enrollment counts are children served by First Class Pre-K as reported to NIEER. Ranks count jurisdictions operating a program in that year (39 in 2002; 46 in 2024–25). Our results are descriptive and carry no claim about adequacy, efficiency, or effects.

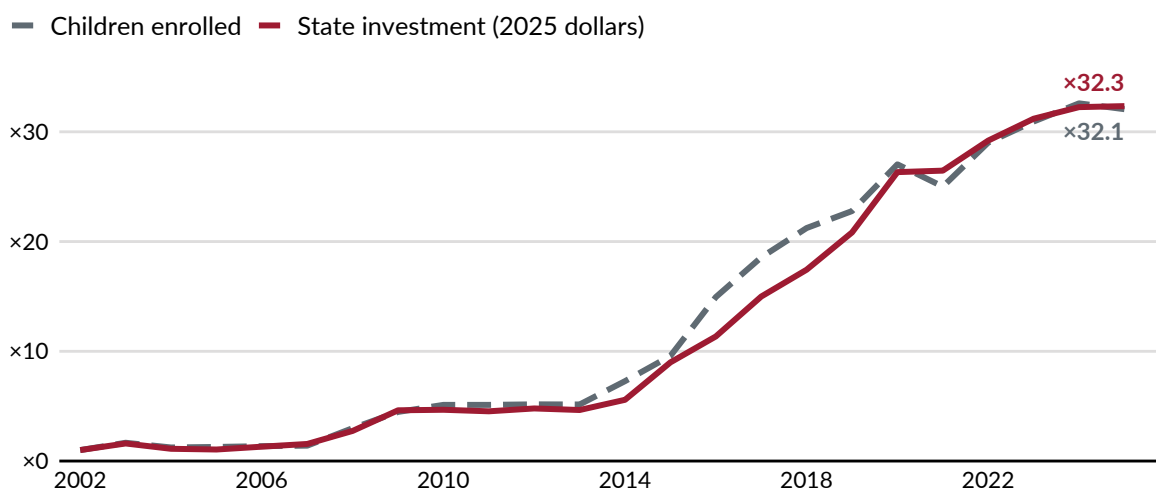
Investment and Enrollment, 2002 to 2025

Indexed to 2002, the state investment curve and the enrollment curve track each other across the full twenty-four years (figure 1). By 2013, the year the state began its sustained expansion push, investment stood at \$26.7 million and enrollment at 3,897; by 2024–25 the corresponding figures were \$185.4 million and 24,238. Over the whole period the two multiples land within a rounding step of each other, at 32.3 for dollars and 32.1 for children.

FIGURE 1

Dollars and Children Grew 32-Fold Together

Alabama state pre-K investment and enrollment, indexed to 2002 = 1, 2002–2025



Source: Authors' analysis of NIEER *State of Preschool* yearbook data, 2002–2025 editions.

Notes: Investment is total state pre-K spending in inflation-adjusted 2025 dollars (\$5.7 million in 2002; \$185.4 million in 2024–25). Enrollment is children served (756 in 2002; 24,238 in 2024–25).

We take the near-proportionality itself, rather than any single year's figure, to be the central finding. Expansion on this scale could have been financed by letting quality-related costs compress, or it could have been accompanied by escalating unit costs; instead, the pattern is more consistent with near-proportional growth, in which each new cohort of classrooms was funded at roughly the same real rate as the last.

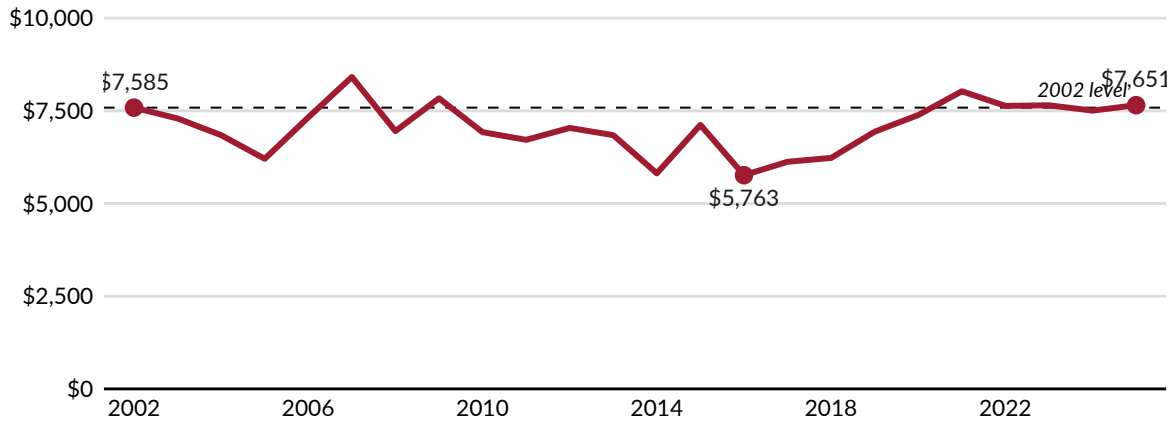
Per-Child Spending over the Expansion

Although the two series track each other over the full period, the proportionality was not exact year to year. In the fastest-growth stretch of the 2010s, enrollment ran ahead of dollars, and those years show a declining real unit rate: per-child state spending slid from \$7,585 in 2002 to a low of \$5,763 in 2016, 24 percent below the starting level, before recovering to \$7,651 by 2024–25 (figure 2).

FIGURE 2

The Price of a Seat Ended Where It Started

Alabama state pre-K spending per enrolled child, 2025 dollars, 2002–2025



Source: Authors' analysis of NIEER *State of Preschool* yearbook data, 2002–2025 editions.

Notes: Per-child values divide total state spending by enrollment; the dashed line marks the 2002 level (\$7,585). The series excludes local and federal funds.

Two features of the dip seem important in retrospect. It was temporary, in that the state restored the real unit rate as appropriations caught up with enrollment, and it did not coincide with any loss of measured standards: 2016, the per-child low point, was also the first year of Alabama's still-unbroken streak on all 10 NIEER benchmarks (brief 4). The episode is nonetheless instructive, because rapid seat growth appears to pull on the unit rate, and holding both is likely to require deliberate appropriations.

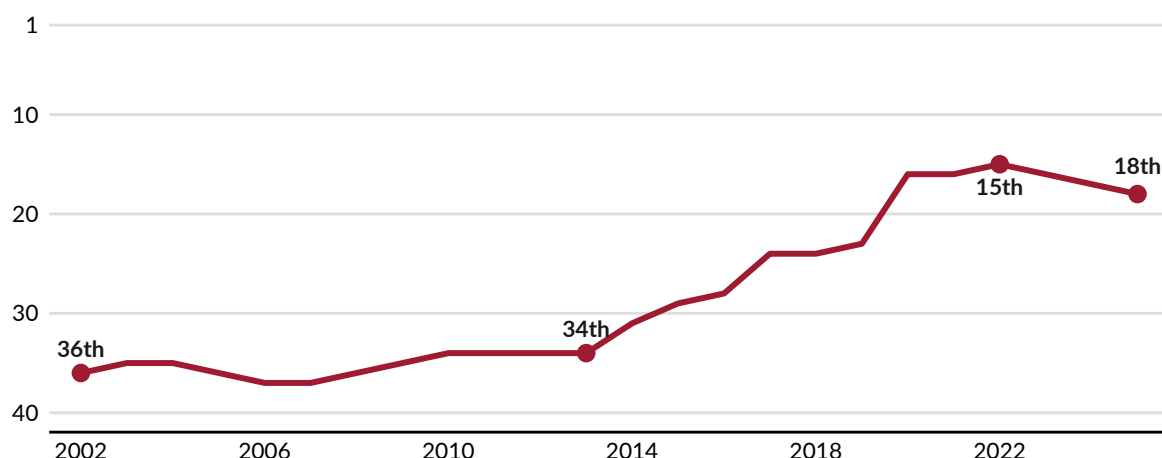
Alabama's National Rank on Enrollment

Moreover, sustained investment is associated with a marked improvement in Alabama's standing among the states. In 2002 Alabama ranked 36th of 39 operating jurisdictions in the share of four-year-olds served; by 2022 it had reached 15th, its best rank, and in 2024–25 it stands 18th of 46 (figure 3). The recent easing from 15th to 18th occurred while Alabama's own share held near 40 percent, which suggests that it may reflect other states' post-pandemic acceleration more than any retreat at home: the share peaked at 41.2 percent in 2023–24 and was 40.3 percent in 2024–25.

FIGURE 3

Alabama Climbed from the Bottom Five to the Top Twenty

Alabama's rank among operating jurisdictions, share of four-year-olds enrolled, 2002–2025



Source: Authors' analysis of NIEER *State of Preschool* yearbook data, 2002–2025 editions.

Notes: Rank 1 is the highest enrollment share. The set of operating jurisdictions grew from 39 in 2002 to 46 in 2024–25, so ranks are not on a perfectly fixed base.

Behind the state totals sits a funding structure that shares the load, because First Class Pre-K grantees must contribute a local match of at least 25 percent, and in 2023, 31.7 percent of all reported spending on the program came from non-state sources. A later brief in this series examines that structure in detail—how a classroom's grant is built, and who pays the rest.

Discussion

We take these patterns to describe a growth model rather than a single result. For twenty-four years Alabama added seats at a near-constant real unit cost, and that record now functions as a benchmark against which the next stage of expansion can be assessed. Whether the next 10,000 seats can be added on the same terms is an open question, because the communities still unserved tend to be those where sites are harder and possibly costlier to open, and budget requests for expansion might reasonably be tested against this baseline rather than assumed to match it.

A second implication is that the per-child rate is, in effect, a policy choice. Holding real per-child spending flat while scaling is a strategy whether or not it was ever debated as one, and proposals that would raise what a seat costs—above all, compensation parity for non-public classrooms, examined later in this series—are proposals to change this line. Framing them that way may make the tradeoff between unit cost and seat count easier to weigh.

The mechanism behind the mid-2010s dip is also worth watching during any renewed expansion, because periods in which enrollment outran appropriations were associated with multi-year erosion

in the real unit rate. Pairing each seat target with its appropriation would likely keep the 2016 episode from repeating at larger scale.

Limitations

These analyses have several limitations. Per-child spending is a quotient rather than a price list: it divides total state dollars by enrollment and moves with both, so it is not a measured cost of serving one child, and it excludes local and federal streams, which make up roughly a third of all reported spending on the program. A constant unit cost is not evidence of adequacy, because the flat line says only that the state scaled proportionally, not that the level of roughly \$7,600 is the right one. Although NIEER compiles them with definitions consistent enough to support trend comparisons, the counts and dollars we report are state submissions rather than audited expenditures. Finally, we make no causal claims: nothing here estimates the effect of pre-K on children or of spending on quality.

Despite these limitations, the twenty-four-year record is consistent in one respect. Alabama expanded one of the nation's most respected pre-K programs largely by multiplying seats rather than the real price of a seat, and whether that arithmetic still holds when the remaining children are the hardest to reach is a question the next decade of data will answer.

References

- Lee, JoonHo, and Alison Hooper. 2026c. "A Decade of Perfect Tens: Where Does Alabama Pre-K Stand in the Nation?" Tuscaloosa: University of Alabama, College of Education.
- National Institute for Early Education Research (NIEER). 2002–2026. *The State of Preschool* yearbook series. New Brunswick, NJ: NIEER.

About the Authors

JoonHo Lee is an Assistant Professor of Education Research at The University of Alabama. He earned his Ph.D. in Quantitative Methods and Evaluation from the University of California, Berkeley. As a Bayesian statistician, he translates methodological innovation into actionable insights on early childhood policy and school finance reform.

Alison Hooper is an Associate Professor of Early Childhood Education at The University of Alabama. She received her Ph.D. in Human Development and Family Studies from the University of Delaware. A former kindergarten and preschool teacher, her research focuses on child care and early education access and quality and educator well-being.

Acknowledgments

This brief is part of the Advancing First Class Pre-K in Alabama project, conducted by The University of Alabama in partnership with the Alabama Department of Early Childhood Education (ADECE). It draws on the publicly available NIEER *State of Preschool* yearbooks; we are grateful to NIEER for maintaining that resource, and to ADECE and the Office of School Readiness for their partnership. The views expressed are those of the authors and should not be attributed to ADECE, NIEER, or The University of Alabama. Any errors are our own.

ABOUT THIS PROJECT

The Advancing First Class Pre-K in Alabama project examines First Class Pre-K funding, implementation, access, and comparisons with other state pre-K programs. Its goal is to offer recommendations for expanding First Class Pre-K while maintaining high levels of quality.

Copyright © August 2026. Permission is granted for reproduction of this file, with attribution to The University of Alabama Early Education Research Office.